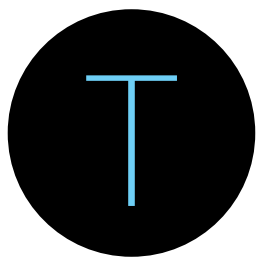


A New Era in E-commerce

The arrival of ONDC has disrupted India's e-commerce space. It will play a pivotal role in empowering millions of customers and merchants



THE ARRIVAL OF India's 'techade' with a focus on '*Jai Anusandhan*' has brought forth a new paradigm of opportunities and possibilities through a focus on innovation. It is an era infused with technological prowess, as seen across the world with the coming of the fourth industrial revolution. The vision for India's techade, however, is unique with an underlying value of empowerment. It's a vision which harnesses a relationship between emerging technologies and those at the margins who have missed out on leveraging the power of these tools. It's our non-digitally enabled small farmers, entrepreneurs, micro, small and medium enterprises, cottage industries, traders, artisans, weavers, etc., spread across the length and breadth of this country, who are being empowered.

Technology isn't being looked at as a tool for simply bolstering economic productivity but for augmenting the productive capabilities of every stratum of society. It is no surprise that India ranks first



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in digital payments, first in data consumption, second in internet users and third in the number of unicorns. A technological structure is being constructed for the welfare of all. In this spirit, focussing on empowering the marginalised, India is undergoing a revolution in the e-commerce sector with the coming of the Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC).

E-commerce has been a boon to our age of connectivity, enabling geography-agnostic commerce. However, as e-commerce platforms grew, so did their market power. This power was misused with customer lock-ins, predatory pricing, malprac-

tices such as algorithms used for forcing consumers to choose certain suppliers and high commissions which were discriminatory to the smaller players. The Indian e-commerce sector, valued at \$46.2 billion in 2020, is poised to touch the \$188-billion mark by 2025. However only 15,000 of 120 million retailers are accessing this e-commerce revolution.

In this context, ONDC was conceived by the Ministry of Commerce, under the leadership of Minister Piyush Goyal and guided by an eminent advisory council. It was conceived to bring forth a sustainable technological paradigm wherein e-commerce can experience systematic and sustainable growth across the value chain. It exists to deliver a vision to enable access to Indian consumers for every merchant regardless of size, location and business offering, promoting choice and empowerment of consumers and committing to those at the margins by on-boarding MSME entrepreneurs on to the network. This is being done by bringing together innovative protocols enabling interoperability across e-commerce platforms on the buyer, seller or logistics end.

ONDC's governance module is transparent and stakeholder-community led. The focus has been to ensure superlative privacy and security protection for each entity on the network. It also promises to have a state-of-the-art online dispute resolution process such that the